

WE MAY BE MAKING SOME PROGRESS, BUT THE STIGMA AROUND SEX TOYS PERSISTS

when Durex vibe rings or condoms were not seen as one? Their justification was that the latter brought pleasure to sexual organs. Our argument was sound, but they considered us the enemy of Indian culture, and there was not much we could do. But, then, Bollywood movies started showing women using vibrators having orgasms. The audience went berserk; within two-three weeks after *Lust Stories* (2018) was released, we sold out all kinds of vibrators. This can be considered the first turning point in our journey—where our industry grew from a toddler to a teenager. The next two years brought the demand for toys for women on par with that for toys for men. The female traffic went from 20-22 per cent to 45-50 per cent. Then came the Covid-19 pandemic.

Later, when the markets opened and we could deliver our orders, the entire business boomed. And how! Our sales doubled and we finished 2020 at 40 per cent higher sales than in 2019. The post-pandemic era can be described as one where sexual wellness as a business category stepped out of puberty into adulthood. There is more acceptance, demand has soared and we are investing in new and upcoming homegrown companies to build the foundation of a new India, where asking, shopping or wanting to invest in a pleasure product for your sexual health is as normal—and even required—as taking care of your mental and physical health.

However, no matter how much we celebrate this new wave of thinking, the fact remains that this acceptance of pleasure and pleasure products has come from a very small fraction of Indian society. The majority continues to feel that desire for pleasure or conversations around sex have no place in our culture and make you look like a pervert or 'abnormal'. We may be making small progress in broadening the mindset of Indians, but most households still stigmatise the use of sex toys. The INDIA TODAY sex survey 2023 also underlines this: a majority of respondents noted that they wouldn't admit to using sex toys, and that they wouldn't even date someone who uses them. Nonetheless, that technology has democratised sex and pleasure is a ray of hope. You no longer need to travel to Paris or Bangkok to get your favourite vibrator, nor do you need to walk down the aisles of Palika Bazaar or the glitzy floors at Emporio Mall to purchase them. Today, you can see, compare, research and shop anywhere and anytime you wish, with a few taps on your smartphone. And the last time we checked, over 700 million Indians had a smartphone.

Not only does technology level the playing field for all classes of society when it comes to accessing and owning sex toys of their choice, it also makes a tremendous impact on our sex lives. These toys, which have been perfected with technology and have evolved through the years, can transform your sexual pleasure with the switch of a button and some imagination. Regardless of whether you use them for solo play, with a partner or with multiple partners, there is always a finish line you will cross, which may otherwise have been a challenge for many in the past. Tech in new-age toys can stimulate your erogenous zones and awaken or speed up your climax while delivering newer sensations to your body that you may never have thought possible. For partners who may lose interest in sex over a period of time, these gadgets come as a new experience. For the curious who are yet to experience sexual pleasure with a partner, the same gadgets double up as training tools. They give people's 'me time' an upgrade and a new definition.

As Indians, we gave the world the *Kama Sutra*. Now, over 2,000 years later, we are about to reclaim our place in the sun and step into a decade that may bear a real sexual revolution for our generation. While haters gonna hate, seeking pleasure is not a fad or a disease, and thus it doesn't have to invite embarrassment or stigma. It's a bodily need, just like food and water. The day it will be okay for a parent and a child to discuss puberty, sex organs, childbirth, reproduction, pregnancy, contraception and menstruation, we as a nation will finally have become progressive and sex-positive. Till then, let us knock on closed doors and stir up conversations. ■

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